

“WE MUST NOT FOR A MOMENT FORGET THAT IT IS THE BIRTHRIGHT OF EVERY INDIVIDUAL TO RECEIVE AT LEAST BASIC EDUCATION, WITHOUT WHICH HE CANNOT DISCHARGE HIS DUTIES AS A CITIZEN.”

A scholar and a fighter

Abul Kalam Azad, as he would come to be known, was born in Mecca, Saudi Arabia, to an Indian father and an Arabic mother. He grew up in Calcutta, where his father home-schooled him in a rigorous curriculum. This included the study of several languages as well as mathematics, philosophy, history and Islamic theology (Azad also taught himself English, despite his father’s disapproval). As a young adult, Azad grew interested in the nationalist movement. Unlike some fellow Muslims, he became convinced early on that India needed to be independent of the British. He even founded a journal named *Al-Hilal* in which he argued for the cause of Indian independence, suggesting that Indian Muslims must work towards freedom.